

Narrative Crossroads

Character Analysis Through Roleplaying for Literary and Historical Study

Core Framework Guide

This guide introduces Narrative Crossroads, a tabletop roleplaying framework designed to help students analyze literary characters and historical figures through structured gameplay. The system combines the analytical benefits of character study with the engagement of roleplaying to deepen understanding of motivations, decisions, and themes.

Framework Overview

Narrative Crossroads engages students in character analysis through five integrated components:

1. Character Selection
2. Threshold Moment Exploration
3. Character Interview Process
4. Decision Resolution Mechanics
5. Reflection and Analysis

The framework uses simplified percentile dice (d100) mechanics to add structure and unpredictability to character analysis, creating a dynamic learning experience that works particularly well for engaging reluctant readers and multilingual learners.

Key Components in Detail

1. Character Selection

Students select or roll for a character from the text they’re studying. Each character has pre-assigned percentages in three core skills:

- **Confrontation** — Physical actions, conflicts, and challenges
- **Comprehension** — Understanding, insight, and problem-solving
- **Connection** — Social interactions and relationships

Percentages reflect who the character *is* in the text, supported by evidence, not who students want them to be:

Band	Range	Meaning
High	60–75%	The character excels here
Medium	40–55%	Competent but not exceptional
Low	25–40%	A weakness or blind spot

Example Character Skills

Character	Confrontation	Comprehension	Connection
Rainsford	70%	60%	50%
Zaroff	60%	70%	65%

2. Threshold Moment Exploration

Students explore characters at threshold moments—critical turning points in the narrative where the character could genuinely have chosen otherwise. Each threshold moment includes one or two key decisions requiring skill checks.

Example Threshold Moment

Threshold Moment	Decision Points (with Required Skills)
Discovering Zaroff hunts humans	1. Recognizing Zaroff’s hidden meaning (Comprehension) 2. Deciding how to respond (Connection)

3. Character Interview

Students roll 1d10 three times—once for each skill category—to determine interview questions that deepen character

understanding:

- **Confrontation Questions** — Focus on how the character handles challenges and conflicts
- **Comprehension Questions** — Explore the character’s understanding of themselves and their world
- **Connection Questions** — Examine how the character relates to others

The final question is always **“Who are you?”** to solidify character identity.

4. Decision Resolution

At each threshold moment, students face one or two key decisions that require skill checks. Roll d100 against the character’s skill percentage:

Result	Outcome
Roll at or under one tenth of the skill	Critical Success — exceptional outcome
Roll at or under the skill	Success — the character navigates the situation effectively
Roll over the skill	Failure — the character struggles, but gains insight
Roll 96–00	Critical Failure — significant complications arise

The outcome shapes the character’s development and the narrative trajectory.

5. Reflection and Analysis

Students document their character’s experience:

- Write in first person from the character’s perspective
- Connect decisions to broader themes and character development
- Consider how different choices might have altered outcomes

Implementation Guide

Materials Needed

- Two ten-sided dice (d10). Roll one for selection and interview questions; roll both as tens and units for skill checks. A dice-rolling app works equally well.
- Character sheets with pre-assigned skills
- Module sheets with threshold moments and questions
- Student journals for responses

Class Session Structure (45–60 minutes)

1. **Introduction (5 min):** Explain the framework and distribute materials
2. **Character Selection (5 min):** Students roll or choose their character
3. **Threshold Moment (5 min):** Students roll or select their threshold moment
4. **Character Interview (15–20 min):** Students roll for and answer questions
5. **Decision Resolution (10 min):** Students roll for decisions and document outcomes
6. **Reflection (10–15 min):** Students connect their character analysis to themes

Accommodations for Multilingual Learners

- Sentence frames for interview responses
- Visual character cards showing traits and skills
- Pre-teaching vocabulary in threshold moments
- Partner options for collaborative analysis
- Audio recording alternatives to written responses

Assessment Options

- **Character Journals:** Written responses in the character’s voice
- **Audio Character Studies:** Recorded interview responses
- **Alternative Scenarios:** Exploring different decision outcomes
- **Comparative Analyses:** Contrasting character motivations

- **Thematic Connections:** Linking character decisions to text themes
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Theoretical Foundation

Narrative Crossroads draws from several educational and gaming approaches:

1. **Reader Response Theory** — Focuses on the reader’s interaction with text
2. **Role-Playing Pedagogy** — Uses perspective-taking to deepen understanding
3. **Threshold Concept Theory** — Examines transformative moments in learning
4. **Game-Based Learning** — Employs structured play for analytical purposes

The framework creates a “cognitive apprenticeship” where students externalize their thinking about character motivation through structured roleplay.

Aligning with ELA Standards

Narrative Crossroads addresses numerous Michigan ELA standards across grade levels.

Reading Literature

- **RL.9-10.2** — Determine a theme and analyze in detail its development
- **RL.9-10.3** — Analyze how complex characters develop, interact with other characters, and advance the plot
- **RL.9-10.5** — Analyze how an author’s choices concerning structure create effects such as tension or surprise

Writing

- **W.9-10.1.B** — Develop claims and counterclaims fairly, supplying evidence
- **W.9-10.3** — Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences
- **W.9-10.3.D** — Use precise words, telling details, and sensory language

Speaking and Listening

- **SL.9-10.1** — Initiate and participate effectively in collaborative discussions
 - **SL.9-10.4** — Present information, findings, and supporting evidence clearly
 - **SL.9-10.6** — Adapt speech to a variety of contexts and tasks
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Customizing for Different Texts

Literary Applications

- **Short Stories:** Focus on key decision moments in compact narratives
- **Novels:** Explore character development across multiple thresholds
- **Drama:** Examine dramatic choices at pivotal scenes
- **Poetry:** Analyze personas and voices in narrative poems

Historical Applications

- **Biographical Study:** Explore historical figures at decisive moments
 - **Social Movements:** Examine participant choices during key events
 - **Cultural Transitions:** Analyze decisions during periods of change
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Sample Play Reference

Character: Rainsford (“The Most Dangerous Game”) **Skills:** Confrontation 70%, Comprehension 60%, Connection 50%

Threshold Moment: Being hunted — when Rainsford must create a trap

Decision Point: Creating an effective trap to slow Zaroff’s pursuit **Skill Check:** Confrontation 70% **Roll Result:** 42 = Success

Outcome: Rainsford successfully constructs a Malay man-catcher, transforming from hunted to hunter and setting a psychological trap as well as a physical one.

Sample Interview Response (*Connection question: “What code of conduct do you follow?”*)

“I’ve always believed in fair chase—that hunting requires skill, preparation, and respect for your quarry. I’ve despised needless cruelty or those who hunt merely for the sake of killing. There must be purpose, whether for food, protection, or the genuine test of skill against a worthy adversary. I’ve lived by the hunter’s ethic that you don’t cause unnecessary suffering. That’s why

Zaroff's 'sport' disgusts me so profoundly—it violates every principle I hold. Yet now, as I set traps designed to maim or kill him, I wonder if survival supersedes all codes. Does my ethical stance change when I'm fighting for my life? I still believe in my principles, but I'm learning that morality looks different when you're the one being hunted."

Version 2

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